Inglenook

RUTHERFORD *Storied Vineyards*

BY MARYANN WOROBIEC

When it comes to grapevines, Rutherford is one of Napa Valley's big names. But as far as towns go, Rutherford is a blink-and-you'll-miss-it spot along Highway 29 about halfway up the valley. As you drive past a former railroad station you might catch the smoky aromas of expertly grilled food at Rutherford Grill without realizing you've just passed through the heart of a town with a population of only about 100. On Rutherford Cross Road, there's a small post office, the Rancho Caymus Inn and La Luna Market & Taqueria, a go-to for locally favored Mexican food. But this sleepy appearance belies that Rutherford boasts a rich wine history shaped by some of the region's most important trailblazers.

The indigenous Mishewal-Wappo people first inhabited the land that now includes present-day Yountville, Oakville and Rutherford. In 1836, authorities granted nearly 12,000 acres on the valley floor to George C. Yount as part of the Rancho Caymus land grant. In 1864, Yount gave his daughter Elizabeth 1,040 acres in the center of the modern-day AVA as a wedding gift when she married Thomas Rutherford. The Rutherfords planted vineyards and produced wine, while giving the town its name.

The Rutherfords' parcel changed hands several times before Finnish fur trader and sea captain Gustave Niebaum acquired it in 1879. He founded Inglenook and built its semi-Gothic château in 1887; the building still stands. After Prohibition ended, his grand-nephew John Daniel Jr. crafted a series of extraordinary wines until he sold the estate in the 1960s. In 1975, filmmaker Francis Ford Coppola purchased the estate; he worked reunite the original property and transform it into a popular tourist destination.

French chemist Georges de Latour had arrived in California in 1883 and built his fortune in the cream of tartar business, an important baking ingredient that is a natural byproduct of winemaking. In 1900, he moved to Napa Valley and founded Beaulieu Vineyard on land adjacent to Inglenook. He also became the first to import phylloxera-resistant rootstock. In 1938, de Latour hired winemaker André Tchelistcheff at BV and under his direction, the Georges de Latour Private Reserve Cabernet became one of the most famous wines in the world.

Rutherford sits at the widest point of Napa Valley, where fewer mountain shadows allow more sunlight to reach the vineyards. The benchlands divide into two distinct areas. On the eastern edge, complex soils and varied microclimates fold into the Vaca Mountains. Volcanic soils dominate much of this terrain and remain moderately deep, but the mountains delay sunrise and slow the warming of the vines.

The western benchland receives morning sun and gains protection from afternoon heat when the sun dips behind the Mayacamas Mountains. This side of the valley features more alluvial soils and experiences cooler, windier conditions that create a drying effect.

Tchelistcheff coined the term "Rutherford Dust," in reference to dusty, powdery alluvial soils on the west side, and the distinct subtle grain and minerality they imbue in the AVA's Cabernets. There are few simple pleasures as fine as sipping a Rutherford Cabernet while some Rutherford Dust clings to your shoes after a day in the vineyards.

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WHERE TO TASTE

Cathiard Family Estate

1978 Zinfandel Lane | cathiardvineyard.com

The late Daniel Cathiard built an impressive career in wine, purchasing Bordeaux's Smith-Haut-Lafitte in 1990, then buying (and renaming) the former Flora Springs estate at the base of the Mayacamas mountain range in 2020. Management was just transitioning to the family's next generation when Cathiard died earlier this year. A visit makes it clear how deeply the family is dedicated to this property, with meticulously maintained grounds and intimate visit experiences that might include a tour of the vineyards in an electric Range Rover, including the wine *cave* and on-site cooperage.

Cathiard

Inglenook/Niebaum; Pennino

1991 St. Helena Highway | inglenook.com; niebaumpennino.com

Even if you didn't know Francis Ford Coppola owned Inglenook, you'd still pick up on how cinematic and grand the estate is, a mix of history, beauty, movie memorabilia and elegant wines. There are plenty of visitor experiences available, from simply enjoying a glass to more informative tours and library tastings. The recently opened Pennino House on the property is another chance to taste wines in a relaxed atmosphere, like stepping into a family home with a cozy living room plus plenty of outdoor seating. Here they also serve a curated selection of Italian-inspired non-alcoholic beverages.

Quintessa

1601 Silverado Trail | quintessa.com

Quintessa lies an easy turn off of the Silverado Trail, but a visit here takes you off the beaten path, into the heart of Rutherford and a uniquely serene setting. The entire property is nearly 300 acres, and the best way to soak it all in is through the "Quintessential Experience," where a tasting takes place in a private glass pavilion overlooking Dragon Lake.

Staglin

Beaulieu Vineyard

1960 St. Helena Highway
bvwines.com

Cakebread

8300 St. Helena Highway
cakebread.com

Caymus Vineyards

8700 Conn Creek Road
caymus.com

Dakota Shy Wine

771 Sage Canyon Road
dakotashywine.com

Foley Johnson Winery

8350 St. Helena Highway
foleyjohnsonwines.com

Frog's Leap Winery

8815 Conn Creek Road
frogsleap.com

Grgich Hills

1829 St. Helena Highway S.
grgich.com

Honig Vineyard and Winery

850 Rutherford Road
honigwine.com

Mumm Napa

8445 Silverado Trail
mummnapa.com

Round Pond Cellars

875 Rutherford Road
roundpond.com

Rutherford Hill Winery

200 Rutherford Hill Road
rutherfordhill.com

Sequoia Grove Winery

8338 St Helena Highway
sequoiagrove.com

St. Supéry Estate Vineyards & Winery

8440 St. Helena Highway
stsupery.com

Sullivan Rutherford Estate

1090 Galleron Road
sullivanwine.com

Staglin Family Vineyard

1570 Bella Oaks Lane | staglinfamily.com

There's much to learn from a visit to Staglin, beginning with the viticultural history of the property, which dates to 1864. Significant figures such as André Tchelistcheff and Beaulieu founder Georges de Latour have ties here, drawn to this place that clearly defines what makes the Rutherford Bench an amazing place to grow grapes.

For more than 40 years, the Staglin family has been the caretaker, including piecing together parts of the property that had been separated from the original, such as the Steckter home, which is now their base for hospitality. The winery remains family-run, with second-generation vintner Shannon Staglin at the helm.

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WHERE TO EAT

shoot Rutherford Grill

Rutherford Grill

1180 Rutherford Road | rutherfordgrill.com

It would be easy to simply think of Rutherford Grill as the best place to pair expertly crafted barbeque with rich Napa Cabernets. But there's so much more to enjoy, including deviled eggs, a generous iceberg wedge salad, oak-grilled salmon and iron skillet cornbread bites. The staff is friendly and the patio seating is popular when weather permits.

La Luna Market & Taqueria

1153 Rutherford Road

lalunamarket.com

The Restaurant at Auberge du Soleil

180 Rutherford Hill Road

auberge.com/auberge-du-soleil/dine

WHERE TO STAY

Rancho Caymus Inn

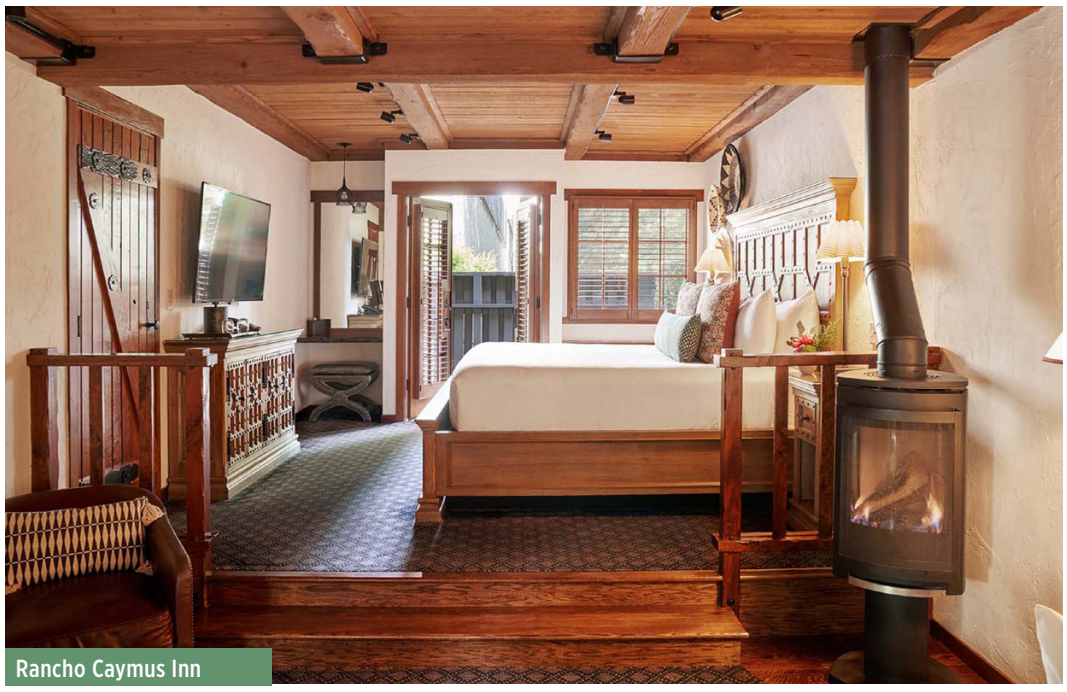
1140 Rutherford Road | ranchocaymusinn.com

Recently renovated, this inn has plenty of personality. It was originally designed and built by the Morton Salt heiress Mary Tilden Morton, who leaned into Spanish-hacienda architecture with 19th-century barn wood beans and wrought iron details. Today, it's the Goldilocks of Napa Valley hotels; it has quiet vibes in the tiny town of Rutherford, but also is conveniently located halfway up the valley and close to much of the vineyard action. Rooms are air-conditioned and feature fireplaces and private balconies or patios.

Auberge du Soleil

180 Rutherford Hill Road

auberge.com/auberge-du-soleil



Rancho Caymus Inn

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A RUTHERFORD ADVENTURE

from MaryAnn Worobiec

THE SAUVIGNON BLANC DISCOVERY TOUR

Napa may be Cabernet country, but many of its red wine specialists also craft exceptional Sauvignon Blancs (not to mention that Sauvignon Blanc is one of Cabernet Sauvignon's parents, along with Cabernet Franc). White wine lovers have plenty to celebrate with these refreshing, expressive wines.

Several standout producers lie close to one another, making it easy to explore. Start at **Groth** in Oakville and choose a tasting that features the estate Sauvignon Blanc. The experience highlights how Napa has transformed Sauvignon Blanc from an afterthought into a deliberate, dynamic category. In the 1990s, the Groth family—now in its second generation in wine—recognized that certain clay-heavy vineyard blocks planted to Cabernet suited white varieties better. They began replanting, helping to usher in a new era for the grape. The estate Sauvignon Blanc, first released with the 2019 vintage, exemplifies that vision.

St Supery

Grgich Hills

Just 3 miles away, Rutherford's **St. Supéry** welcomes guests with one of the valley's most approachable tasting experiences. The winery farms its Sauvignon Blanc at Dollarhide Ranch in Pope Valley, east of Napa, and has championed distinctive expressions of the grape since the 1980s. Today, it remains a category leader. Several tasting flights spotlight Sauvignon Blanc, including the "White Wine Discovery," which demonstrates how fermentation vessels from stainless steel to French oak barrels and concrete fermentors shape the wine's texture and style.

In season, try St. Supéry's Mustard Season Tasting Flight. The winery pairs red and white wines with artisan pretzels, Journeyman sausages and house-made savory mustards. You can also opt for a white wine and caviar pairing to explore how Sauvignon Blanc and Sémillon complement the delicacy.

When hunger strikes, head down Highway 29 to **Mustards Grill**. The ever-popular seafood tostada changes daily but typically arrives on a large, crisp tortilla layered with black beans, cabbage-jicama slaw and avocado, and then finished with chipotle aioli and cotija cheese. It pairs beautifully with a glass of crisp white wine.

Finish your Sauvignon Blanc tour at **Grgich Hills Estate**. This historic family-run winery continues to earn attention for its role in the Judgment of Paris anniversary, but its Sauvignon Blancs deserve equal acclaim. The wines show aromatic intensity, floral lift and distinctive character, with select bottlings available only at the winery. Choose a tasting flight that includes them, or order a glass—or bottle—and enjoy it in the garden.

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